The Baathists seize power 1968

Key question
How did the Baathists extend their power?

Key date
Baathists seized power: 1968

The Baathists, supported by some army officers, seized power in 1968. Most of them were Sunni Muslims. The Sunnis had been the dominant group in Iraq ever since the state of Iraq was set up in 1921, although the Shiite Muslims formed the majority of the population. Many Shiites were now brought into the new government in a show of unity. More money was spent on defence and the army, in particular. In 1972, the Baathist government nationalised, and took complete control of, the Iraqi oil industry, despite the opposition of the British. This was a daring and popular move.

Sunni and Shiite

There was a major disagreement over who should succeed Muhammad as the Caliph, or leader (in Arabic, it literally means deputy or successor) of the Muslim world. Ali, the cousin and son-in-law of Muhammad, believed he should be leader and was recognised as Caliph in Iraq and Persia (modern Iran). But the Syrian Muslim rulers chose another successor. This led to a great division and warfare among Muslims with the creation of two groups: the Shia, or Shiite, Muslims who followed Ali, and the Sunni Muslims. Most of the Arabs became Sunni Muslims while the Arabs of southern Iraq and the (non-Arab) Persians became Shiite Muslims.

Then, in 1973, the Iraqis joined other Arab oil-producing states in reducing oil production and sales to Western countries. This was done to punish the West, who depended on oil from the Middle East, for their support of Israel in the Yom Kippur War (see page 56). However, it also had the effect of driving up oil prices by 400 per cent. Iraq's income from oil was to rise from $575 million in 1972 to $26,500 million in 1980.

As the country became richer, the Baathists brought about undoubted improvements: electricity was extended to the countryside; and roads, bridges, hospitals, schools and dams were built. The Iraqis became a more educated population and health care improved. An urban middle class of lawyers, businessmen and government officials emerged. The Baathists also became much more powerful, extending their control over Iraqi government and society. Trade unions, schools and even sports clubs came under state control and membership of the Baath Party determined public appointments. The main aim of education was to immunise the young against foreign culture and promote Arab unity and 'love of order'. The ideal student was one who could 'stand in the sun holding his weapon day and night without flinching'. So said the up-and-coming strong man in the government, Saddam Hussein.

Saddam Hussein and rule by terror

In the 1970s Saddam Hussein was the government minister responsible for extending government control over the army and the secret police. High military spending kept the armed forces